project.org

STUDENT HANDOUT

YELLOW LEVEL
GRADE LEVEL

Seeing Through Deception

Grades 6–8 · Library

ADMIT ONE

NAME _____ DATE _____ CLASS _____

Lateral reading in practice. Professional fact-checkers don't read suspicious sources deeply — they leave the site immediately and search for information ABOUT that source. This is called lateral reading.

01

PART 1

Evaluate three sources

Apply the SIFT method to each source:

SOURCE	I: WHAT DID YOU FIND ABOUT THIS SOURCE?	F: WHO ELSE COVERS THIS?	VERDICT
A viral tweet with "breaking news" but no link			
A Wikipedia article about a historical event			
A blog post with strong opinions and no citations			

02

PART 2

Historical analysis

How could Victorians have used “lateral reading” to verify spirit photographs?

Why didn’t they? What psychological factors made them want to believe?

What modern misinformation exploits similar psychological vulnerabilities?

03

PART 3

Key insight

Why does lateral reading work better than reading deeply on a suspicious site?

MINI MUSEUM CONNECTION

Spirit photography targeted grief; deepfakes target political division and sensationalism. The TECHNOLOGY changes but the HUMAN responses remain constant — making critical evaluation skills timeless.

minimuseumproject.org/exhibitions/seeing-is-deceiving/illusions

SHARE WITH YOUR FAMILY

Find something online that seems suspicious. Walk your family through the SIFT process to evaluate it together.